

Pilot corpus-based analysis of emotional vocabulary and experiencer constructions in Hittite

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This paper proposes a pilot corpus-based analysis of emotional vocabulary in Hittite, drawing on material assembled in the semantic database of the project *Akkadian and Hittite Emotional Concepts in Context* (AHEC, DFG #49525771).

Emotional concepts have recently attracted considerable scholarly interest in cuneiform studies (Galhano 2022; Sonik and Steinert 2023; Molina and Uvarova 2026, in print), yet a statistically grounded corpus analysis of the Hittite emotional lexicon remains a desideratum. The publication of AHEC materials makes it possible to undertake a comprehensive quantitative study of emotionally relevant contexts documented in the project: <http://hittite-emotions.net>.

The research is structured in two stages with distinct methodological profiles.

The first stage consists of a lexical-statistical analysis carried out in R. A pre-compiled list of Hittite emotional lexemes derived from the AHEC database is applied to a larger Hittite corpus, including critical editions of myths, rituals, and prayers published on HPM and the full TLHdig dataset published on Zenodo. This makes it possible to identify lexically expressed emotional contexts automatically. The resulting frequency data, distributional patterns, and genre-based breakdowns will be made available on GitHub (Pankin and Molina 2026). This stage is descriptive and quantitative: it establishes the empirical base for subsequent analysis by documenting the distribution of emotional vocabulary across text genres and generating the annotated dataset on which the second stage depends.

The second stage focuses on the grammatical level, specifically on the analysis of experiencer constructions in Hittite within a *Construction Grammar* framework. *Construction Grammar* is employed as a descriptive and analytical tool for examining the grammatical encoding of emotional semantics: the way in which lexical selection, argument structure, and discourse context together form an emotional event. The variables structuring the analysis include genre, emotion lemma, emotion macrodomain, predicate type, construction type, and the overt expression of the experiencer, target, and causal participant.

The proposed paper focuses on the first stage and offers preliminary quantitative results from the second stage. Participation in the *Academia Grammaticorum Salensis 2026*, with its courses in *Diachronic Construction Grammar* and *Inferential Statistics*, will serve as a direct preparatory step for the second stage of the project.

The contribution of this research is twofold. First, it provides a genre-sensitive quantitative account of the Hittite emotional lexicon based on a systematically annotated corpus subset, filling a gap in the quantitative study of Hittite. Second, it demonstrates how a semantically structured philological dataset can serve as the basis for a constructional analysis.

References

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Online Resources and Datasets

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